

HOUSE BILL 696

By Gillespie

AN ACT to amend Tennessee Code Annotated, Title 4;
Title 8 and Title 38, relative to sexual assault
response teams.

BE IT ENACTED BY THE GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE:

SECTION 1. This act is known and may be cited as the "Statewide Sexual Assault Response Team (SART) Coordinator Act."

SECTION 2. Tennessee Code Annotated, Title 38, Chapter 1, Part 9, is amended by adding the following as a new section:

38-1-904. Statewide SART coordinator.

(a) There is created a statewide sexual assault response team (SART) coordinator.

(b) The statewide SART coordinator is responsible for ensuring the proper training, compliance, and effective functioning of local SARTs in accordance with this part. The statewide SART coordinator shall provide statewide leadership, coordination, technical assistance, and oversight to ensure the proper functioning of sexual assault response teams, including training, compliance with applicable laws, and access to necessary resources.

(c) The statewide SART coordinator is an employee of the Tennessee Coalition to End Domestic and Sexual Violence and shall report directly to the executive director of the organization.

(d) Subject to appropriations, the statewide SART coordinator position is funded by grants from the department of finance and administration, office of criminal justice

programs, to the Tennessee Coalition to End Domestic and Sexual Violence for such purpose.

(e) Not later than February 1 annually, the statewide SART coordinator shall submit a report to the chief clerks of the senate and the house of representatives and the legislative librarian on the status of the SART program throughout the state, including training efforts, compliance levels, and recommendations for improvement. The coordinator shall also report on the effectiveness of SARTs in responding to sexual assault cases, identifying gaps in service, and addressing systemic challenges.

SECTION 3. The heading in this act is for reference purposes only and does not constitute a part of the law enacted by this act. However, the Tennessee Code Commission is requested to include the heading in any compilation or publication containing this act.

SECTION 4. This act takes effect July 1, 2025, the public welfare requiring it.